

A REFLECTION ON GROWTH

Self-Reflection

How looking back gently can grow you forward

Simplify to Glorify

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Created with care for women in hard and ordinary seasons alike.

Self-Reflection

You have a sense, somewhere underneath the busyness, that the last year held more than you have yet taken from it. Lessons you brushed past. Patterns you almost saw. A quieter wisdom waiting for you to slow down long enough to notice it.

That instinct is right, and it is worth trusting. Reflection is how experience becomes wisdom instead of just becoming the past. But it is also a practice that can quietly turn against you, and most of us were never taught the difference. So let me walk you through it gently, the way I would over coffee.

What self-reflection really is

Self-reflection is the honest review of your thoughts, feelings, and actions with the intention to learn and to change. That last part is what gives it life. Without it, what looks like reflection can become something heavier.

There are two things that feel like reflection but are not. The first is rumination, the same painful thought played on a loop, going nowhere. The questions circle, the mood drops, and nothing actually shifts. The second is mindfulness, simply being present without analyzing. It is good and worthy, but it is not the same work. True reflection looks at what happened, draws meaning from it, and reaches for one small change to carry into next time.

Why it grows you

Most of life moves too fast for us to see what we are actually doing. Reflection slows the tape down so the patterns can surface. The way you brace when someone criticizes you. The kind of day that leaves you hollow. The decision you keep making and keep regretting. Once you can see a pattern, you can finally do something with it.

Reflection also has a way of revealing your real values. When you look back at the choices you are proud of and the ones you would undo, your true priorities come into focus. Most of us carry a stated set of values and a lived set, and reflection is one of the few honest mirrors that shows where the two have drifted apart.

A simple rhythm

You do not need a system. You need a rhythm small enough that you will actually keep it. First you reflect, naming what happened and what you felt. Then you act, choosing one small, specific change to try. Not a list of changes, which only overwhelms. One. Then you review, coming back after a week or so to see whether that change is taking root or needs adjusting.

If you want a place to land, the simplest version is three questions at the end of the day. What went well. What did not. What is one thing worth carrying forward. Start there, and add more only if it actually helps.

When reflection starts to hurt

This is the part most articles skip, and it is the part I most want you to hear. When the same painful question gets asked again and again with no action and no mercy, it stops being growth and becomes a slow erosion. Watch for the warning signs. A mood that keeps sinking. Self-talk that has turned harsh. A sense of being frozen, unable to decide.

A few gentle guardrails keep the practice healthy. Give your reflection a time limit. Ask curious questions like *what is this trying to teach me*, instead of accusing ones like *why am I always like this*. Always end with one small step forward. And speak to yourself the way you would speak to a dear friend sitting across from you.

Where faith makes the difference

For those of us who follow Christ, this practice is not new at all. The church has examined its own heart for centuries. The Psalms are full of people naming hard feelings honestly before God, and Paul urged the Corinthians to examine themselves.

But faith adds something the studies cannot. It changes who is in the room. A reflection practice on your own has only you and your thoughts, and your thoughts can be a harsh company. A reflection practice held before God has you, your thoughts, and a Father who is already committed to your good.

*Search me, God, and know my heart; Put me to the test and know my anxious thoughts;
And see if there is any hurtful way in me, And lead me in the everlasting way.*

Psalm 139:23-24, NASB 2020

Notice that David is not auditing himself alone in the dark. He is inviting God in, and the searching happens with mercy already in the room, not as a verdict waiting to fall. Paul names where all of this is meant to lead, in his call to be transformed by the renewing of your mind. That kind of growth comes a little at a time, and it lasts.

A gentle thirty-day start

If you are beginning from nothing, try this for a month and let it be small. Pick one fixed time, ideally at the end of the day, and give it five minutes. Ask what stood out, what you learned, and one thing to carry into tomorrow. Once a week, read back over the days and look for a single thread. At the end of thirty days, take an hour to ask what changed, what did not, and what is worth continuing.

That is the whole practice. It is small enough to actually do, structured enough to actually grow you, and gentle enough that on the hard days you can still show up. And small, faithful things have a way of compounding, over months and years, into the very person you have been hoping to become.

A Prayer for the Searching

Father, You know my heart better than I do, and You are not afraid of what You find there. I bring You my honest looking back, the parts I am proud of and the parts I would undo. Search me gently, with mercy already in the room before any verdict. Renew my mind a little at a time, in the slow and patient way You have always worked. And when I cannot see clearly, remind me that the growing is Yours to finish, not mine to force. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Reflecting with God: A Simple Evening Examen

Long before journals and self-help shelves, Christians ended their days with a quiet practice of looking back over the day in God's company. It has carried different names in different centuries. The shape of it is simple, and it takes about five unhurried minutes at the end of the day.

Begin by settling. Sit somewhere quiet, breathe slowly, and remember that you are not reviewing the day alone. Then give thanks, naming two or three mercies the day held, even small ones like a kind word or a finished task. Next, walk back through the day gently, noticing where you felt close to God and where you felt far away, without rushing to explain either one.

Then name one thing honestly. If something needs confessing, confess it and receive the forgiveness that was already waiting. If something needs grieving, grieve it. Finally, look at tomorrow with grace. Choose one small thing to carry forward, and hand the rest back to the God who manages the world while you sleep.

That is the whole practice. Done before God, the looking back stops being an audit and becomes a conversation. You may find it is the gentlest part of your day.

Questions That Open Instead of Accuse

The questions you bring to reflection decide whether it heals or harms. Accusing questions close the heart and start the spiral. Curious questions open the heart and start the learning. When you catch yourself in the left column, borrow from the right.

INSTEAD OF ASKING	TRY ASKING
Why am I always like this?	What is this trying to teach me?
What is wrong with me?	What was I needing in that moment?
Why can't I just get over it?	What would help me take one small step?
How did I fail today?	Where did I see grace today?
Why did I say that?	What was underneath those words?
Why can't I be like her?	What has God given me to work with?

The right-hand questions are not softer on the truth. They are simply the questions a good friend would ask, and you are allowed to be a good friend to yourself.

A Gentle Health Check

Reflection should leave you a little freer than it found you. Every few weeks, hold your practice up to this page and see which column it has been living in.

HEALTHY REFLECTION LOOKS LIKE	TIME TO PAUSE AND REACH OUT
Curiosity about your patterns	The same painful question circling for weeks
A mood that settles as you write	A mood that sinks every time you reflect
One small step you want to try	Feeling frozen and unable to decide
Speaking to yourself like a friend	Self-talk that has turned harsh
Ending with grace and a next step	Ending with shame and no way forward

If the right-hand column has become your normal, that is not a failure of character or of faith. It is a sign you were never meant to carry this look-back alone. A trusted friend, a pastor, or a good counselor can sit with you in it, and letting them is one of God's mercies, not a detour from Him.

The Daily Three

The smallest version of the practice, made to be kept. Five minutes at the end of the day, before God, with no performance required. Print a fresh page as often as you like.

Date

What went well today...

What was hard today...

One thing worth carrying forward...

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE PAGE

Search me, God, and know my heart. Thank You that the searching happens with mercy already in the room. Amen.

Stated and Lived

Most of us carry two sets of values, the ones we name and the ones our hours reveal. This page sets them side by side, gently. The gap you find is not a verdict. It is simply the next place grace gets to work.

What I say matters most to me

What my time actually went to this week

One small way to move these two columns closer together...

A WORD FOR THE GAP

Father, You see the distance between what I value and how I live, and You are not ashamed of me. Close the gap a little at a time, Your way. Amen.

The Thirty-Day Look

A companion to the gentle thirty-day start. Check in once a week, then take a longer look at the end of the month. Threads only become visible when the days sit side by side.

WEEK	WHAT STOOD OUT	A THREAD I NOTICE
One		
Two		
Three		
Four		

At month's end: what changed, even slightly...

What is worth continuing next month...

FOR THE LONG VIEW

Lord, thank You that growth is Your project before it is mine. Keep me faithful in the small look-backs, and finish what You started. Amen.

More Resources

If you want to reflect in a way that grows you rather than wears you down, these verses invite God into the searching. Return to them when self-examination starts to feel harsh.

Psalm 139:23-24

David invites God to search his heart, so the examining is done with mercy already in the room.

Romans 12:2

Growth is the slow renewing of the mind, not a performance you have to perfect on your own.

Lamentations 3:40

We are invited to examine our ways and turn back to the Lord, gently and without self-condemnation.

2 Corinthians 13:5

Paul calls us to examine ourselves in the faith, looking honestly for the evidence of Christ in us.

Psalm 19:14

A prayer that the words of our mouth and the meditation of our heart would be pleasing to God.

Philippians 1:6

The good work God began in you, He will carry on to completion; growth is His project, not only yours.

Notes

A Note Before You Go

If these pages met you in a hard place, I'm so glad. Please know that nothing on your worst day disqualifies you from being deeply loved by God.

If you'd like to keep going, my journals, scripture cards, and devotionals are gentle companions for longer seasons – grief, caregiving, depression, and more. You can find them at simplifytoglorify.com.

With love and prayers,

Carla

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